CS180 – Problem Solving and Object-Oriented Programming

Course Information

CS18000 – Problem Solving and Object-Oriented Programming
Course credit hours: 4
From January 12, 2026 to May 9, 2026

Course Description

This course serves as the starting point for students in Purdue's Computer Science program and is popular as an introductory course to programming for students in other programs. The course is broadly divided in three parts. The first module (week 1-5) focuses on Computer Science fundamentals and familiarizing students with the basics of modern imperative programming languages. The second module (week 6-12) focuses on the discipline of Object Oriented Programming (OOP), I/O, concurrency and Graphical User Interfaces (GUIs). The course ends (week 12-14) with recursion and data structures.

At the end of the course students are expected to be able to reason through simple programs, translate simple procedures to code, understand OOP, and use basic data structures for problem solving.

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Textbooks

- Start Concurrent: An Introduction to Problem Solving in Java with a Focus on Concurrency, Wittman, Mathur, and Korb. The teaching slides in the course are based on this book!
- Think Java: How to Think Like a Computer Scientist, Allen B. Downey and Chris Mayfield, Version 6.1.0, 2016.
- Oracle Java Website
- Introduction to Programming Using Java, David J. Eck, Version 7.0, August 2014.
- A Comprehensive Introduction to Object Oriented Programming with Java, Thomas Wu. NOTE: Any version of this book is fine. You do not need the latest version.

Prerequisites

As stated in the Computer Science Prerequisite Flowchart, the course prerequisite is MA 16100, 16300, 16500, 16700 or other approved math courses (may be taken concurrently).

Learning outcomes

A student who successfully fulfills the course requirements will understand:

- How to solve problems through analysis and algorithm design
- How to implement algorithms in a high-level programming language
- How to use data types and strings, selection, repetition, arrays, methods and classes, inheritance, exceptions, polymorphism, and recursion
- How to implement simple graphical user interfaces
- How to perform file I/O
- How to debug programs

Preparion for class

You should try to read over the relevant pages in the course text before lecture. Additionally, you are expected to check your email, the course website, and the course newsgroup regularly. Due to Purdue IT's approach to email, you must also monitor your junk folder and spam reports. Email from the instructor is often flagged as spam. Here is the tentative lecture schedule:

Week		Topics	Book
01	1/12	Introduction to Computer Science and Programming	Ch 1 & 2
02	1/19	Primitive Types and Strings	Ch 3
03	1/26	Selection	Ch 4
04	2/02	Repetition	Ch 5
05	2/09	Arrays	Ch 6
06	2/16	Methods and Classes	Ch 8, 9
07	2/23	Midterm 1, 2/23 8:00-10:00 PM, Up to Arrays	
		File I/O and exceptions	Ch 20, 12
08	3/02	Interfaces & Inheritance	Ch 10, 11
09	3/09	Concurrent programming and synchronization	Ch 13, 14
N/A	3/16	Spring Break	
10	3/23	Network communication and simple GUIs	Ch 21, 7
11	3/30	Midterm 2, 3/31 8:00-10:00 PM, Up to Concurrency	
		Constructing graphical user interfaces	Ch 15
12	4/06	Polymorphism and Dynamic Data Structures	Ch 17, 18
13	4/13	Dynamic Data Structures	Ch 18, 19
14	4/20	Recursion	Ch 19

Course Infrastructure

Synchronous

This is a face-to-face course and relies heavily on synchronous, in-person sessions. It is in your best interest to attend all lectures and labs and create connections with both the teaching staff and other students taking the class. However, you should stay home if you feel ill.

Lecture

Lecture is the starting point of all material in the course. All other parts of the course build upon the material shown here. You are expected to attend lectures barring an emer-

gency. I employ the Socratic method meaning that lectures might be interactive, you are expected to answer questions and most of the time we will be introducing material with questions rather than answers.

In-class Quizzes

For quizzes we will use iClicker Cloud. You should get the iClicker Student app for your phone. Log in to iClicker Cloud using your Purdue Career Account login and password. Sign in through the campus portal "Purdue University West Lafayette/Indianapolis" and search for "Spring 2026 CS 18000-LE1", or "Spring 2026 CS 18000-LE2". Click the "Add This Course" button.

We will give at least one in-class quiz each day and will use it for your quiz score: 2 points for the correct answer 1 point for an incorrect answer 0 points for not taking the quiz

The lowest 4 days of quiz scores will be dropped. This can account for any personal situations, sickness, or reasons you may need for being absent from class as we know unforeseen circumstances can come up which may prevent you from attending class.

During class students will be given 2 minutes to answer the iClicker Cloud question. Please be sure to input your answer during this time frame.

If an error prevents you from submitting your answer during these 2 minutes, you will need to present a time-stamped screenshot of your error or reason preventing you from doing so to your Head TA at the end of the same class session. Emailing us after class is **not a valid option**.

You can expect to see your quiz score updated on Brightspace by the end of the class day. Please check your grades frequently and immediately notify your Head TA if there are discrepancies. It is your responsibility to verify these grades are correct and to notify the Head TA within a timely manner (1 week) of these being posted.

Missed quizzes cannot be made up. However, you may ask your Head TA to make you exempt from a day's quizzes if you have to miss class due to serious illness, broken leg, or some other situation beyond your control.

Office Hours

Office hours are designed for you to bring additional questions on the material and assignments. However, they are not designed for obtaining assignment answers or debugging code. Course staff will help with your conceptual ideas, but **will not actively debug your code.** Instead, will focus on discussing pseudocode to help refine your logical approach. Prepare to explain your pseudocode solutions and engage with questions aimed at refining your approach. You're responsible for translating any guidance into actual code on

your own time, ensuring we can assist as many students as possible during these sessions due to limited capacity.

Instructor Office Hours are exclusively for further understanding of material. If you have a personal matter you wish to discuss, send an email to your Head TA with the title **CS180 1-on-1 meeting**.

Any alteration to Office Hours will be announced on Brightspace and/or Ed. There are no office hours on weekends, breaks, observed days, or finals week.

Labs

Attendance is mandatory. Students must attend their respective, registered lab session. Lab assignments are distributed at the beginning of the session and due before your next lab session begins. There are no extensions. A well-prepared student should have no problem completing the assignment in the allotted time. Labs will not meet in Week 1.

Midterms & Final Exam

You will have two (2) midterms and a final exam. Be prepared for short-answer questions or multiple-choice questions. Read each question carefully and respond succinctly (i.e., a long answer does not guarantee full points, but a correct and concisely explained answer does).

Bring your Purdue ID, pens, pencils, sharpener, and eraser for each exam. Exams will be closed book and closed notes. You must solve the exam problems yourself, without any help (knowing or unknowing) from any other student. You must not seek any knowledge in advance of the test questions (beyond that given in class) and must report any advance knowledge of the test questions by any student that you are aware of. You must not allow any other student access to your solutions during the exam. If the seating situation makes this difficult, please inform the instructor or TAs.

No electronic or digital devices are permitted (unless stated otherwise); the use of such will result in an automatic zero score and a formal report to the Office of Student Rights and Responsibilities.

Exam	Date	Time	Duration	Topics
Mid1	Monday, February 23, 2026	8:00 PM	120 minutes	Up to Arrays
Mid2	Tuesday, March 31, 2026	8:00 PM	120 minutes	Up to Concurrency
Final	See Registrar		120 minutes	Everything covered in the course

Students with DRC-approved testing accommodations must arrange their midterms with Purdue Testing Services (PTS) to coincide with the announced schedule. We encourage students with DRC accommodations to register the midterms and the final exam promptly with PTS. Keep in mind that we are not responsible for missed deadlines with PTS or long processing times with the DRC. Cheat sheets collected at PTS will be securely retained for review and returned upon request at the end of the exam period.

Missing a midterm without valid justification results in a zero score. An absence must be approved by the Office of the Dean of Students; only then will we discuss a make-up midterm. See Absences for more information. No exceptions will be made outside of this process.

Asynchronous

Assisting the synchronous part of the course is a plethora of asynchronous platforms. Leaning is completed only when you **apply** the concepts yourself. Additionally, announcements and further discussion may be outside scheduled instructional times.

Brightspace

We use Brightspace for the course management system. This is the home of our course and your first stop for any course related question. Familiarizing yourself with the platform is crucial for your success in this course. Explore the site, especially the left-hand course menu containing the course content and student resources. Start by reading the items on the Course Homepage. This page is your central hub, providing links to critical course deadlines, help files and detailed instructions for commencing your studies.

Ed discussion

Ed Discussion is our platform for online Q&A. Here's how to make the most of it:

- Before your first post, familiarize yourself with the Netiquette section.
- Collaboration is encouraged. Answering questions and elaborating on topics enhances everyone's understanding.
- Consider this a chance to hone formal and technical communication skills, reflecting the collaborative spirit of the global computer science and software development community.

Ed is an academic platform for questions and answers and we expect you to communicate appropriately. You must maintain a professional attitude when using it. You can post general questions about the topics, course assessment, programming, debugging, basic Java, or other relevant subjects.

Don't expect immediate responses. Continue exploring your problem through course materials, online resources, or further debugging. You must emulate what professionals do: Seek answers actively, and if you find one, share it on Ed. This will help you and aid your peers who might face similar challenges. Do not expect replies during weekends, observed days, and breaks. Remember that TAs are students like you with commitments, yet they are willing to assist you with your learning experience. Staff will respond to appropriate posts within 24 working hours (i.e., Monday to Friday, 9:00 AM to 5:00 PM).

Refer to Netiquette for appropriate rules on online communication in the course.

Homeworks

There are a total of 14 homeworks, one for each week of instruction. Homework 1 releases on Brightspace at **6 pm Mon Jan 12** and is due at **6 pm Fri Jan 16**. For Homework 1 you will complete four sub-modules - "Academic Honesty", "Vocareum", "Debugging", and "Course Policies". Homework 1 ends with a quiz. You must answer the questions in this quiz. Students **MUST** complete Homework 1 in order to access any other course assignments.

All subsequent homework assignments will consist of **Walkthrough**, **Debugging**, and **Challenge** sections. Each section ends with a deliverable that must be submitted in order to complete the homework. The Walkthrough and Debugging parts of each homework are intended to be completed in lab. You will also begin the Challenge part in lab. (Some of you may finish by the end of lab.) Each Challenge will be due one week later at the beginning of the lab. Challenges can be turned in late at a penalty of 10% per day late with a 72 hour maximum. There is an initial grace period of two hours from the original deadline before any penalty applies.

Projects

You will also have five graded programming projects throughout the course. Projects will be released on some Mondays at 6:00 PM and be due two weeks later on Sunday at 11:50 PM. We allow late submissions with a penalty of 10% per day late with a 72 hour maximum. There is an initial grace period of two hours from the original deadline before any penalty applies.

You must read the project descriptions carefully before you start working on them. Do your best to understand the context of each part and identify the concepts covered in class that will help you to solve it. Use Ed Discussion, labs, and office hours to discuss doubts or guidance. The TAs will provide assistance through the venues indicated in this document, but they need you to do initial work and show some understanding of the topics.

Programming projects will be completed in Java, adhering to the specific requirements and submission guidelines detailed in each project description. The projects are designed to be completed within the allotted time. Therefore, starting early is crucial. You must submit your source code, including all required and additional files, to Vocareum by the deadline.

Vocareum is for grading, not debugging. It will compile, run, and evaluate your code against provided and additional internal test cases (the latter will remain undisclosed). We will provide some test cases for you to check the efficacy of your code locally in your machine, yet these are not exhaustive. You must anticipate and test additional scenarios independently. Review your approach if your code works locally but not on Vocareum (e.g., correctness, robustness, and performance). Then, check technical code aspects such as access modifiers, including statements, identifier initialization, and file I/O. Debugging and ensuring compliance with the project requirements is your responsibility.

Adherence to the project's technical specifications is critical. Code that works locally but fails on Vocareum likely omits certain scenarios. You must identify and rectify these before final submission. Remember that we disable print statements from submitted source code files before execution. Projects that do not compile receive 0 points. No manual reviews or regrades will be provided if your submission fails to meet the technical requirements. Strive for a robust solution that considers a wide range of potential cases.

Grading Scheme

The advent of generative systems has cast doubt to the veracity of student work outside the classroom. As a result, the grading emphasis gravitates to in-class evaluations.

Category	Weight
Class quizzes	5%
Homework Assignments	10%
Programming Projects	5 x 2 = 10%
Midterms	2 x 25 = 50%
Final Exam	25%

The following describes how each letter grade corresponds with your performance in the class

The following standard will be used as a guide:

- A+, A Superior performance in all aspects with work exemplifying the highest quality. Unquestionably prepared for courses building on CS180.
- A- Superior performance in most aspects; high-quality work in the remainder. Prepared for courses building on CS180.
- B+ High-quality performance in all or most aspects. Considered prepared for courses building on CS180.

B	High-quality performance in some; satisfactory performance in the remainder. Good chance of success in courses building on CS180.
B-	Satisfactory performance. Evidence of sufficient learning to succeed in courses building on CS180.
C+	Satisfactory performance in most of the course. Evidence of sufficient learning to succeed in courses building on CS180 with effort.
C	Evidence of learning but generally marginal performance.
D	Demonstrated minimal learning and poor performance in all aspects.
F	Complete absence of evidence of learning.

Policies

Netiquette

In all your interactions we expect you to be civil and professional. Our course is a place of **learning** and our goal is to be welcoming to all. When interacting with course staff and other students be mindful of the different life experiences that Purdue students come in with and that your own experiences are not universal. Avoid the use of esoteric slang and cultural abbreviations. Reflect on your messages before posting and how they will be received. Welcome and seek feedback. If you are in a argument with another student, do not be defensive, but instead try to understand their point of view. Misunderstandings, especially in how certain problems are solved, are expected and open communication can help dispel them.

Monitor your participation to ensure everyone has an opportunity to contribute. Inappropriate messages (e.g. attacking the course staff, out-of-line comments, opinionated posts, unsolicited advice or opinions, hate speech, etc) may result in disciplinary action and restrictions in the public forum participation in this course.

Late work

We allow late submissions with a penalty of 10% per day late with a 72 hour maximum. There is an initial grace period of two hours from the original deadline before any penalty applies. The two hour grace period is intended for dealing with unforeseen circumstances (such as slow internet). To make use of any late submission, you do not need to contact any course staff; everything is automated.

We reserve the right to not accept late work on **manually** graded assignments. Any such change to the late work policy will be specified in the assignment itself.

Absences

We recognize life's unpredictability but aim to maintain fairness and equity for everyone. We require official notification from relevant university offices to consider any absence or extension request. Types of notifications issued by the Office of the Dean of Students (ODOS):

- Grief Absence: ODOS notification for a death in the family or of a close friend.
- Medical Excuse: ODOS notification for hospitalization, emergency, or urgent care visits.
- Jury Duty: ODOS notification for jury service obligations.
- Quarantine: ODOS notification if ordered to quarantine by a medical provider.
- Minor Health Events: Medical Excused Absence from ODOS for standard health issues.
- Accessibility Issues: DRC letter/request due to an accident affecting cognitive or physical functions.
- Other Official Notifications: Any other verified notice from ODOS or the DRC.

For medical excuses, ODOS must validate your medical notes due to privacy concerns. We dismiss emails or meetings disclosing medical information.

For Military duties or official Purdue representation (e.g., sports, arts, conferences), we require the respective notification letter emailed to the instructor(s) at least two weeks in advance. We dismiss notification letters sent post-missed deadlines.

Important Notes:

- We reserve the right to verify the authenticity of all paperwork for extension requests.
- Dishonesty will lead to disciplinary action.
- No extensions will be granted without approved notification from ODOS/PUSH/DRC. You are responsible for meeting deadlines in case of unapproved absences.

Academic Integrity & Collaboration

We abide by Purdue's Academic Integrity definitions and guidelines. All submissions and work are subject to checks for dishonesty through manual inspection, auxiliary material review, or detection software. Any student found to be dishonest will score zero on the respective assignment and must discuss the issue with the Academic Integrity TA(s) within a week of the grade release.

While all course activities are individual tasks, discussing the topics and strategies for solving the problems with your study group is allowed and encouraged. However, the work you submit must be **entirely your own**. For example, meeting with a friend to discuss an approach is encouraged, but writing code next to each other and checking in with each other every few lines might be an Academic Integrity violation.

To enforce academic integrity, course staff can at any time request a student to briefly and orally explain their submitted work.

Penalties for academic dishonesty:

- **First offense:** Zero on the assignment, a letter grade deduction at the end of the semester, a report to the Office of Student Rights and Responsibilities, and notification to the Department of Computer Science.
- **Second offense:** Zero on the assignment, further letter deduction at the end of the semester, notification to the Department of Computer Science and a report to the Office of Student Rights and Responsibilities.
- **Third offense:** Immediate course failure with an F grade, a report to the Office of Student Rights and Responsibilities, and notification to the Department of Computer Science.
- **Dishonesty during midterms or the final exam:** Immediate course failure with an F grade, a report to the Office of Student Rights and Responsibilities, and notification to the Department of Computer Science.

Remember, any instance of academic dishonesty will be reported as per the Department of Computer Science Academic Integrity Policy. Always strive for integrity in your work to maintain the course's fairness and your academic credibility.

Use of Artificial Intelligence

As we navigate this revolutionary era of AI technology, it's crucial to understand its appropriate use within this course. While AI tools are powerful and can produce sophisticated results, some will be flawed. Professionals across job sectors are responsible for identifying such flawed results before using them. Not doing so constitutes professional dishonesty and a violation of corporate policies. Therefore, as a student aiming to become a professional, you must be held accountable when using AI tools in academic settings. Keep in mind that AI tools serve best as productivity enhancers, not replacements for human expertise (at least for now).

Critical skills like mathematical reasoning, logical thinking, and original creativity exceed AI's current capabilities. We focus on developing these critical human skills, particularly concerning data structures and algorithms.

We encourage using AI for personalized learning, such as generating clearer explanations or creating interesting examples for practice. However, using AI to complete course assessments undermines your learning experience and skill development and is considered academic dishonesty. No course evaluation documents (e.g. quizzes, homeworks, projects, exams, etc) or part thereof may be uploaded to AI systems. Be aware of the inequity in access to various AI tools, some requiring payment. To ensure academic integrity, we use proprietary tools to compare student submissions with AI-generated content across multiple platforms.

Only substantial overlaps or unique errors indicative of direct AI use will trigger further investigation. Dependence on AI for tasks like coding might offer short-term gains but can jeopardize long-term success and understanding. Remember, AI tools won't be available

during midterms and the final exam. Consider the broader implications of over-reliance on AI: you aim to be a skilled professional, not someone limited by the capabilities of these tools.

Here's something for you to think about: "Coding and mastery of AI tools can help you get a job, but not to keep it. You don't want to be the 'professional' proposing range queries on a hash table."

Accessibility

Purdue University strives to make learning experiences accessible to all participants. If you anticipate or experience physical or academic barriers based on disability, you are encouraged to contact the Disability Resource Center at: drc@purdue.edu or by phone: 765-494-1247, as soon as possible.

If the Disability Resource Center (DRC) has determined reasonable accommodations that you would like to utilize in my class, you must send me your Course Accommodation Letter. Instructions on sharing your Course Accommodation Letter can be found by visiting: https://www.purdue.edu/drc/students/course-accommodation-letter.php Additionally, you are strongly encouraged to contact me as soon as possible to discuss implementation of your accommodations.

Accommodated Testing

Students with disabilities whose DRC Course Accommodation Letter (CAL) includes test accommodations must first release their CAL to me and then schedule to take their exams with Purdue Testing Services here. You must schedule at least four days (96 hours) before the exam date listed on the syllabus.

In the case of finals week, you must schedule by the Friday before quiet week. I will provide Purdue Testing Services with your exam and they will proctor it and provide the result to me for grading. Students must inform me immediately of cases when Purdue Testing Services is at capacity or otherwise unable to proctor the exam so that I can make other arrangements. Students who fail to follow this process and meet stated deadlines risk not being able to have their accommodations for that exam.

Copyright

See the University Use of Copyrighted Materials for Educational and Research Purposes policy. Effective learning environments provide opportunities for students to reflect, explore new ideas, post opinions openly, and have the freedom to change those opinions over time. Students and instructors are the authors of the works they create in the learning environment. As authors, they own the copyright in their works subject only to the university's right to use those works for educational purposes. Students may not copy,

reproduce, or post to any other outlet (e.g., YouTube, Facebook, or other open media sources or websites) any work in which they are not the sole or joint author or have not obtained the permission of the author(s).

Research

Your submitted work may be used for research purposes. For instance, anonymized student assignments could be utilized to develop algorithms or create tools aimed at predicting students' performance. If you prefer not to participate, you can opt out by contacting the course staff at any time up to seven days after final grades are released. Choosing to opt out will not affect your grade in any way. To opt out of research participation, contact the instructor via email. You will receive an email confirmation once your request is processed.

Nondiscrimination Statement

Purdue University is committed to maintaining a community that recognizes and values the inherent worth and dignity of every person; fosters tolerance, sensitivity, understanding, and mutual respect among its members; and encourages each individual to strive to reach his or her potential. The full Nondiscrimination Policy Statement is available here.

Mental Health/Wellness Statement

If you find yourself beginning to feel some stress, anxiety and/or feeling slightly overwhelmed, try Therapy Assistance Online (TAO), a web and app-based mental health resource available courtesy of Purdue Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS). TAO is available to all students at any time by creating an account on the TAO Connect website, or downloading the app from the App Store or Google Play. It offers free, confidential well-being resources through a self-guided program informed by psychotherapy research and strategies that may aid in overcoming anxiety, depression and other concerns. It provides accessible and effective resources including short videos, brief exercises, and self-reflection tools.

If you need support and information about options and resources, please contact or see the Office of the Dean of Students. Call 765-494-1747. Hours of operation are M-F, 8 a.m.- 5 p.m.

If you find yourself struggling to find a healthy balance between academics, social life, stress, etc., sign up for free one-on-one virtual or in-person sessions in West Lafayette with a Purdue Wellness Coach at RecWell. Student coaches can help you navigate through barriers and challenges toward your goals throughout the semester. Sign up is free and

can be done on BoilerConnect. Students in Indianapolis will find support services curated on the Vice Provost for Student Life website.

If you're struggling and need mental health services: Purdue University is committed to advancing the mental health and well-being of its students. If you or someone you know is feeling overwhelmed, depressed, and/or in need of mental health support, services are available. For help, such individuals should contact Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS) at 765-494-6995 during and after hours, on weekends and holidays, or by going to the CAPS offices in West Lafayette or Indianapolis.

Basic Needs Statement

If you ever face challenges meeting your basic needs – like food, housing, transportation, healthcare, childcare or access to technology – Purdue can help. Contact the Office of the Dean of Students to seek help with immediate needs and support on campus. Visit www.purdue.edu/odos or email odos@purdue.edu. The Purdue Basic Needs Program connects students with off-campus resources and provides one-on-one basic needs consultation. Visit them at www.purdue.edu/studentsuccess/basicneeds or email basicneeds@purdue.edu.

Emergency Preparation Statement

In the event of a major campus emergency, course requirements, deadlines and grading percentages are subject to changes that may be necessitated by a revised semester calendar or other circumstances beyond the instructor's control. Relevant changes to this course will be posted onto the course website or can be obtained by contacting the instructors or TAs via email or phone. You are expected to read your @purdue.edu email on a frequent basis.

See Purdue's Information on Emergency Preparation and Planning. This website covers topics such as Severe Weather Guidance, Emergency Plans, and a place to sign up for the Emergency Warning Notification System. I encourage you to download and review the Emergency Preparedness for Classrooms document.

The first day of class, I will review the Emergency Preparedness plan for our specific classroom. Please make note of items like:

- The location to where we will proceed after evacuating the building if we hear a fire alarm.
- The location of our Shelter in Place in the event of a tornado warning.
- The location of our Shelter in Place in the event of an active threat such as a shooting.

Course Evaluation

Toward the end of this semester, you will be provided with an opportunity to give feedback on this course and your instructor. Purdue uses an online course evaluation system, and I will not have access to this anonymous feedback until after final grades are submitted. You will receive an official email from evaluation administrators with a link to the online evaluation site and will receive a prompt to complete the survey when you login to Brightspace. The subject line will be: Please take 2-5 minutes to complete the survey. Check your "Junk E-mail" folder occasionally to be sure the evaluation emails were not accidentally routed there. Your participation is an integral part of this course, and your feedback is vital to improving education at Purdue University. I strongly urge you to participate in the evaluation system.